

Q. What are the skills a developer advocate needs?

A. Looking beyond the necessary tech skills, I think empathy is the most important soft skill for developer relations.

Google Cloud is not one single product, but it encapsulates a whole suite of products. There is no single tech or list of skills required. As a developer advocate, I could select a product like Google Kubernetes Engine (GKE), for instance, and create videos and documentation on how it is built and how it should be used. Then the developers are forced to use it the way I am telling them to use it. This doesn't cut it. Hence, when I say empathy is important, I need to understand what the developers want to do with the product and how it will be used further. Hence, empathy is crucial.

With respect to technology skills, I will start by picking (say) three technologies and deep dive into those. For example, I personally enjoy containers, serverless, and AI/ML. We have a lot of serverless products in Google Cloud, and many that are available from other cloud vendors. If I just create tutorials on how to use the serverless products, it is probably not enough. I need to dig deep into my topic; for example, why should somebody use serverless?

I need to help users come to serverless given where they currently are. If I am a desktop developer, why is serverless important for me? If I am an on-premise customer, why is serverless important for me? If I want to move to serverless, how can I do that? What are the steps to do it? Does it take six weeks or a year? This is the depth in technology that is expected from someone in developer relations.

One should take up a few areas that one is passionate about and delve deep into them — how will somebody use these, how can someone that wants to use them get to the desired state, and so on.

Q. How has the developer relations role evolved over time?

A. Developer relations has been a core part of Google. For consumer products, we typically do user research and arrive at a good experience. However, there are products that don't hit end users directly, but somebody in between (developer) has to use the product and build something for end users. This is the way Google Cloud, Android platform, etc, have been developed.

“We work closely with engineering teams and with product management teams. We, as developer advocates, are expected to be technical experts in specialised topics and products. We are uniquely positioned to work closely with the developer community.”

Q. How do developer advocates maintain authenticity when balancing the needs of their company with that of the tech community?

A. To ensure balance, developer relations is a part of the engineering teams. When I am talking to developers, explaining something, I am helping them understand the space and what the product can do. So, for example, we

work towards identifying the need - why they want containers and what is the problem statement they are trying to solve. Are containers really important for them? If not, we stop the conversation there.

For example, maybe what they are doing actually needs compute/VMs and not containers. We educate developers and help them understand what they need. We make people love our product and that's the way we approach any query.

Q. How is the success of a developer advocate measured?

A. We have to show our impact and the value we are bringing in. On one hand, there is the external feedback we get from developers. When we create articles or videos, the number of views is an important metric to note that people are consuming our content. We also get requests for doing sessions, events and community meetups, which indicate the demand for a product; these are measurable numbers.

On the product side, we try to help improve the product. The feedback that is accepted by the engineering or the product team is the impact we create on the product, and is measured as our success.

There are various ways to measure this. For example, some products have a Net Promoter Score. The more people want to interact and work with us, it indicates we are contributing something valuable.

Q. If one part of your role is interfacing between the outside world and the engineering team, does it give you the power to suggest the tech stack for the latter?

A. I wouldn't call it a tech stack. We help influence the external interface of the product at the level it is going to be consumed. If you look at an API or the SDK, we will influence how the community wants to use it. For example, say there is a product where we do the steps in the order of A-B-C, but find that the world outside is probably using the flow as A-C-B.